only to be far from obvious but also, and at the same time, highly divisive. In 2005, the draft European Constitution sparked some bitter exchanges on the issue of the role of Christianity in the formation of Europe. According to one of his close collaborators, Pope John Paul II wanted himself to intervene with the President of the Convention, Valéry Giscard d'Estaing, to have the Judaeo-Christian roots mentioned in the document too, but was discouraged from doing so.[5] In the end – and this appeared to be done under the strong influence of French views on the relationship between Church and State – only a vague reference to 'religious inheritance' remained in the preamble of a document that was later to be abandoned anyway. Indeed, it seemed that one of the biggest problems for those who framed the EU Constitution was to name the sources that inspired the listed European values (rights of the individual, freedom, democracy, equality and the rule of law, justice and solidarity, diversity, pride in national identity and history, etc). The preamble specifically mentioned only 'cultural, religious and humanist inheritance', but failed to say which religion(s) were referred to. It did, however, mention Humanism as a particular philosophical view. But, some asked, if Humanism is there, why not mention Christianity too? The usual explanation at the time was that mentioning one religion would discriminate against the others. The EU returned to this debate with the Lisbon Treaty, but Christianity fared no better and animosity to, or at least unease about its Christian roots, as we shall see later, has continued to haunt Europe to the present day. Worse, doubts began to emerge about Europe's Humanistic roots too.

Some Eastern Europeans, notably the Poles, were particularly unhappy about this disregard for Christianity. The truth is that Humanism, which *was* mentioned, could only have taken root in an originally Christian environment. Moreover, it was mostly a Western and Central European phenomenon. In 'Eastern Europe proper' (i.e. Orthodox Eastern Europe), Humanism only made an appearance from the late eighteenth century, and was even then seen as a Western importation. For an important part of Eastern Europe then, it was Christianity (or Christendom) which provided the basic link with the rest of the Continent.[6] At risk of some over-simplification, here too lies a good part of the underlying causes of the spat between Brussels on one hand, and Poland and Hungary on the other, as I shall elaborate in more detail in the second part of this book